

‘Sono Andrea’: Some reduced (cleft) answers in Italian

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1 Reduced clefts in Italian (phone calls) answers

In answering a phone call in standard Italian, the following exchange typically occurs:

- (1) Q: (Pronto) Chi parla?
A: Sono Andrea

Sometimes the question may remain implicit, as in A’:

- (1) A’: (Pronto) Sono Andrea

or else the answer can correspond to A’ ’:

- (1) A’’: (Pronto) Parla Andrea

These fixed exchanges have, of course, their own syntax, as already noted in Belletti 2004: fn.22 (see also Belletti 2009: chapter 10). One crucial aspect concerns the involvement in all (1) A/A’ and A’ ’ of the clause internal low focus position in the periphery of the verbal

area, hosting the constituent expressing the new information, in a cartographically analyzed TP. Concentrating on the answer in (1)A/A', such constituent is the focal post-copular subject (Moro 1997)¹.

In these notes, I further investigate (1)A/A' by looking more closely at its missing part. Specifically, the missing part should correspond to the deleted sentence in (2), the predicate of the copular sentence in Moro's sense:

(2) Sono Andrea ~~che parla~~

(1)A/A' thus ultimately corresponds to a reduced cleft². Following in its essential aspects the analysis developed in Belletti 2009 and re-

1. As discussed in Belletti 2009: chapter 10, in languages in which the new information focus position is also left peripheral, the resulting order will be 'DP copula' rather than 'copula DP'. One such language is Sicilian, as also witnessed by the famous expression 'Montalbano sono', pronounced by Camilleri's popular *commissario* in precisely the same conditions, i.e. answering a phone call. The point is discussed in some detail in a comparative perspective, in Belletti 2009: chapter 10: (9), (10).

Expressions like (1)A/A' are not to be confused with word-by-word identical expressions in which the postverbal DP is not the postverbal new information subject, answering the (possibly silent) 'Chi parla/Chi è?' question (see also footnote 2 on the latter) discussed here. Rather, in these (identical) expressions it corresponds to the predicate of the copular sentence; the predicate status of the DP in these cases is witnessed by the possibility of pronominalizing it with the pro-predicate Italian clitic *lo*: *pro sono Andrea (I am Andrea) > pro lo sono (I am it)*, as Moro discusses. No Question-Answer pair like Q: 'Chi parla/Chi è?' A: **Lo sono*, is conceivable. This is consistent with the assumption that the structure described in the text is not the one involving the predicate postcopular DP, but rather the one in which the DP is the low new information subject, answering the relevant identification question, along the same lines as (1)A' containing the verb 'parla', as developed here.

2. Belletti 2004: fn.22 also mentions other comparable exchanges like e.g. the following:

(i) Q: Chi è? (somebody knocking at the door)

A: Sono Andrea

In line with the analysis proposed in the text, this type of exchange would also involve a reduced cleft (e.g. *Sono Andrea che bussa alla porta*). The fact that these answers have become totally fixed, almost formulaic, suggests a reason as to why the unreduced version may sound somewhat unnatural.

lated work³, the reduced predicate instantiates a low location of the complementizer in the Fin head of the left periphery (Rizzi 1997, Belletti 2013). The new information focal subject is displaced from the subject-like position in the left peripheral reduced/small clause complement of the copula, into the low focus position in the immediate periphery of the copula in the matrix clause (Spec-FocP/NI). Both the subject-like position in the small clause complement of the copula and the low new information Focus position at the periphery of the copula in the matrix clause have the status of A-type positions. This in turn has the immediate consequence that only subject clefts can be new information clefts; of which (1)A/A' is a (reduced) instance. As discussed in the references quoted, this robustly attested property is a direct consequence of the Relativized Minimality principle, as the clear manifestation of the operation of intervention locality (Rizzi 1990). This crucial aspect is addressed in detail in the references quoted; it is assumed here as a background and will not be further developed.

Let us zoom on the described derivation with the different ingredients just described. For the sake of clarity, the subject-like position in the small clause complement of the copula (*be* in 3) is indicated as the specifier position of a Pred head (as in Belletti 2015); the small clause status of the complement of the copula is expressed through the idea that its complementizer area is reduced. More precisely, it is in fact truncated and does not contain the highest heads of the left periphery, cartographically analyzed along the lines of Rizzi 1997, Rizzi & Bocci 2017⁴:

3. Belletti 2008, 2015, Belletti & Bocci to appear for most recent reassessment including new experimental evidence based on French.

4. As proposed in the references quoted, truncation occurs up to the contrastive Focus head (Foc/C), thus accounting for the selective property of the copula in contrastive clefts, involving the left peripheral focus position located in the reduced small clause complement of the copula. The main insight is that, despite identical word order, new information clefts and contrastive clefts involve two different positions: the new information focus position (Foc/NI) in the matrix clause at the periphery of the copula and the contrastive focus position (Foc/C) in the complement of the copula.

- (3) ...[FocP/Ni Andrea [*be* [ForceP ... [TopP [FocP/C [Pred ... [FinP *che* [TP — parla]]]]]]]

The FinP predicate is left unpronounced, yielding the elliptical (1) A/A' as in (4), with the copula raised to T in the matrix clause:

- (4) [[T *be* [FocP/Ni Andrea [<*be*> [... [FinP *che* [TP — parla]]]]]]]

As already discussed in the references quoted, the small clause complement of *be* in clefts parallels in relevant respects that of the pseudo-relative complement of perception verbs (along the same lines of Guasti's 1993 original proposal). Whence the expected parallelism between the exchange in (1) and the one in (5). The latter can be analyzed as in (6), with the subject of the pseudo-relative raised into the specifier of the new information Focus position in the matrix periphery of the vP 'vedere' (and then raised into the past participial head).

- (5) Q: Chi hai visto che parlava con Maria?

A: Ho visto Andrea

- (6) ... [PstPrt visto [FocP/Ni Andrea [<*visto*> [ForceP [Top [FocP/C [Pred ... [FinP *che* [TP — parlava con Maria]]]]]]]

2 An agreement puzzle

Before concluding these notes the following agreement puzzle is now addressed: in the reduced cleft answer (1)A/A' 'sono Andrea' the noun phrase 'Andrea' is the focus of new information answering the (possibly non explicit) question '(Pronto) Chi parla?'. The basic insight of the proposal illustrated in (3) of section 1 is that this is the same position occupied in general by a new information post-verbal subject. For instance, a postverbal subject as the one of the other possible answer in (1)A" 'Parla Andrea'.

The two answers (1)A/A' and (1)A'', - 'Sono Andrea' and 'Parla Andrea'- differ, however, in one crucial respect: in the former the verbal agreement on the copula is at the first person singular 'sono', i.e. agreeing with the speaker, whereas in the latter the verbal agreement on the verb is at the third person singular 'parla', i.e. agreeing with the 3rd person noun 'Andrea'. The remaining lines of these notes are devoted to the outline of a proposal suggesting a possible route for an account of this contrast.

Note first of all that next to the typical answer in (1)A/A' 'Sono Andrea', also the less typical one 'È Andrea' is not excluded; the latter is a grammatical possibility, that simply does not correspond to what has become as the standardized, formulaic form (1)A/A'.⁵ 'È Andrea' is thus the equivalent of 'Parla Andrea', when the verb 'parlare' is used instead of the copula, with agreement with the postverbal new information focus subject in both cases: a standard grammatical option in Italian. Hence, the real question is the following one made explicit in (7), which is in fact twofold and split in (7)a, b:

- (7) a. Why is first person agreement possible in the answer with the copula?
- b. Why is this possibility not available in the answer with the verb 'parlare'?

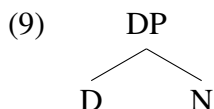
Indeed, (8) as an alternative to (1)A'' and equivalent to (1)A/A' is totally excluded:

(8) *Parlo Andrea

A possible route to look for a solution to this agreement puzzle can be sketched out along the following lines. Assume that the DP containing the proper name 'Andrea' may or may not have first person

5. An interesting possibility to check is whether in those central varieties of Italian in which auxiliary 'essere' does not agree with a plural postverbal subject (e.g. 'È arrivati Gianni e Andrea', interestingly pointed out by a reviewer) a possible answer to the similar question 'Chi è?' mentioned in footnote 1 could be 'È Gianni e Andrea' rather than the standard agreeing form 'Siamo Gianni e Andrea' (reduced form of 'Siamo Gianni e Andrea ~~che bussiamo alla porta~~'). Some new insight could come from this comparison, left open here for further development.

singular features in its D head (a possibility available when the DP coincides with the speaker).⁶ Given the (simplified) structure in (9), the agreement possibilities illustrated in (10-11) are then available, depending on whether both D and N are expressed overtly, or else either only D or only N:



- (10) For *be*:
- a. Sono io Andrea
 - b. Sono Andrea
 - c. *È io Andrea
 - d. È Andrea

- (11) For *parlare*:
- a. i. Parlo io Andrea
 - b. *Parlo Andrea
 - c. *Parla io Andrea
 - d. Parla Andrea⁷

The agreement pattern with the copula in (10a-c) indicates that agreement goes with the features in D, with the 1st person singular D remaining silent in (10b). (10d) should be possible under the assumption that N has raised to D; in this case D should be considered empty of phi-features, hence N-to-D takes place as in the standard analysis of proper names from Longobardi 1994 on to guarantee argument status to the proper name. As for (11), (11c) is directly excluded for feature mismatch on the verbal agreement, as D is (overtly) first

6. Different functional head positions should correspond to the different nominal features in the noun phrase. I simplify the picture here to highlight the main points, and only make reference to one functional D head.

7. Possibly, in (10a) and (10b) the noun 'Andrea' is in turn emarginated (Antinucci & Cinque 1977) into a low topic position, below the new information Focus position (Belletti 2004).

person singular. As for (11b), corresponding to (8), it can be excluded assuming that N-to-D has occurred, hence leading once again to agreement mismatch (the mirror situation as the one in (11c)). If this interpretation is on the right track, it indicates that it is only with the copula that the DP allows for a silent D endowed with first person singular phi-features as in (10b), with consequent possible lack of N-to-D in this type of structure.

This residual intriguing puzzle, which crucially singles out the copula (Moro 2017), is left open here for future investigation.

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